

A WALK ON THE BUY SIDE

I'VE OVERSIMPLIFIED THIS ANALYST BUSINESS JUST TO GET US THIS far. There's a further complication: the buy-side analyst. The big investors employ these buy-side analysts just to interpret what the Nancy Halls and Diana Temples have been telling them five times a day on the telephone. That I'd only been talking to sell-side analysts is something I discovered at the end of my investigation.

It happened as follows. During one of my conversations with Ms. Hall, she told me that the biggest investor in Gillette was Citicorp—with something like 1.6 million shares. What Citicorp might be doing with its 1.6 million shares was of great personal interest. If they decided to dump their 1.6 million all at once because some analyst advised them to sell, I assumed it might have a depressing effect on the value of my 53.

When I expressed this fear to Ms. Hall, she gave me the name of the person to contact at Citicorp—their buy-side analyst, Valerie Molter. That's the first I'd heard of the buy-side analyst.

I called Ms. Molter and recited the string of sell-side analysts I'd already seen, as evidence of my importance. She agreed to meet with me. Soon I found myself on an upper floor of Citicorp headquarters on East Fifty-third Street, the building with a piece lopped off the top. There was no fancy lobby on Ms. Molter's floor, perhaps because the buy-side doesn't deal with the general public and can forgo the expensive impression. Maybe they'd spent the money on robots; as Molter and I walked back toward her cubicle, I almost tripped over one as it tried to deliver me some mail.

I warmed up to my eventual question about the 1.6 million shares